

THE LION KING

WORKING DRAFT OF: August 20, 1993

Written by

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Music by Elton John

Lyrics by Tim Rice

IN DARKNESS:

A Native African VOICE calls out in SONG.

FADE IN:

Dawn. The sun slowly rises over an African plain -- full, brilliant.

Native African VOICES respond in SONG. The SOLO VOICE continues, joined by the group.

CLOSE ON

ANIMALS - alert to the sound: a RHINO, TOPIS, MEERCATS, a CHEETAH, several MARABOU STORKS. Another marabou stork enters frame. Intro SONG: "THE CIRCLE OF LIFE"

The stork takes wing.

EXT. VICTORIA FALLS

The rising sun lights the cascading water. The marabou storks fly across frame.

EXT. PLAIN WITH KILIMANJARO IN B.G.

ELEPHANTS walk along through the morning mist.

AERIAL SHOT - A RIVER

Flocks of airborne FLAMINGOES cast shadows on the meandering waterway, below.

GAZELLES

leap and run across a grassy plain.

EXT. A HILL

A MOTHER GIRAFFE crests the hill, followed by her baby, as the song lyric begins:

VOICE
(singing)
FROM THE DAY WE ARRIVE ON THE
PLANET
AND BLINKING STEP INTO THE SUN
THERE'S MORE TO SEE THAN CAN EVER BE
SEEN
MORE TO DO THAN CAN EVER BE DONE

The mother and child giraffes cross frame and reach a crest that overlooks a huge migration of animals. They lope down the hill to join them. We HOLD ON:

A TREE BRANCH

where ants carrying leaves march across. RACK FOCUS to reveal:

ZEBRAS

below -- trotting in the same direction as the rest of the herds.

DOWN SHOT - GUINEA FOWL

waddle toward us... as dust reveals:

A HUGE ELEPHANT

who crests an incline and lumbers toward us... The guinea fowl scamper ahead. One is almost stepped on by the elephant's huge hoof.

EXT. A STREAM

reflecting the morning sun. The reflection is shattered by ZEBRA who leap into the water and cross - causing an explosion of shimmering droplets. In the b.g., AN ELEPHANT with birds perched on its head and tusks gives them safe passage across the stream. PAN to see the animals getting out of the stream and joining a SCREENFUL of animals, all walking in the same direction.

VOICE (CONT'D)

THERE'S FAR TOO MUCH TO TAKE IN
HERE
MORE TO FIND THAN EVER BE FOUND
BUT THE SUN ROLLING HIGH
THROUGH THE SAPPHIRE SKY
KEEPS GREAT AND SMALL ON THE
ENDLESS ROUND

The light changes. PAN to REVEAL:

EXT. PRIDE ROCK - CONTINUOUS

An impressive mountain: with many plateaus, levels and textures. It stands castle-like in the center of the Pride lands.

VOICE (CONT'D)

IT'S THE CIRCLE OF LIFE
AND IT MOVES US ALL
THROUGH DESPAIR AND HOPE
THROUGH FAITH AND LOVE
ON A PATH UNWINDING
TILL WE FIND OUR PLACE

IN THE CIRCLE
THE CIRCLE OF LIFE

AERIAL SHOT - CONTINUOUS

WE TRACK in with a hornbill (ZAZU) who flies over the gathered animals and ANGLES up, up, up to the promontory.

He lands and bows regally to an O. S. character. He gestures with his wing, indicating that all is ready... and reverently backs away.

ANGLE - MUFASA

The rising sun lights this regal, commanding lion (MUFASA) -- who acknowledges Zazu with a warm nod.

REVERSE ANGLE

Below, the animals are collected in a natural amphitheater.

WITH MUFASA

Surveying the situation.

WITH THE ANIMALS

Gourds and on the top of a walking stick make their way through the crowd. An old baboon (RAFIKI) -- who carries the walking stick -- hobbles out from the crowd, toward Pride Rock. There is mystery and humor to this old fellow as he ambles forward and scales the cliff.

EXT. EDGE OF PLATEAU, ABOVE

Rafiki's head pops up. He ambles to a standing position, goes right to Mufasa and gives him a hug. Mufasa beams. These guys obviously go way back. They turn and look at:

A LIONESS

(SARABI) who has her newborn cub (SIMBA) nestled at her feet.

FULL SHOT

Mufasa lovingly nuzzles Sarabi. Then he nuzzles the little cub.

MUSIC UNDER:

ANGLE - THE CUB

Rafiki looks at him. He shakes a gourds on his walking stick over Simba and they RATTLE. He cracks a gourd open and smears some goo on the little guy's forehead. He takes a handful of dirt and sprinkles it over Simba. Simba SNEEZES. Mufasa and Sarabi, doting parents, think this is adorable.

RAFIKI

ever-so-carefully lifts Simba and carries him to the promontory of Pride Rock. He holds the cub up for all to see.

The animals react with glee: ELEPHANTS trumpet; MONKEYS applaud and do somersaults; ZEBRAS stomp.

THE SKY

A shaft of sunlight shines down through the clouds on the future king.

THE ANIMALS

bow and genuflect grandly.

SUMMIT OF PRIDE ROCK

Rafiki holds the cub high. Mufasa and Sarabi watch.

VOICE (CONT'D)

IT'S THE CIRCLE OF LIFE
AND IT MOVES US ALL
THROUGH DESPAIR AND HOPE
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MUSIC OUT.

FADE OUT

TITLE CREDIT: "THE LION KING"

SEQ. 1.2 (SCAR, ZAZU, MUFASA)

FADE IN:

A ROCK SURFACE - A SHORT TIME LATER

A chameleon blends in with its terrain. Its eyes shift. It walks away. PAN DOWN the rock to reveal a shadow... then a dark crevice.

DARKNESS

Two little eyes dart erratically across FRAME. As b.g. becomes lighter, we realize that the eyes belong to a FIELD MOUSE.

EXT. SHADE TREE AREA - CONTINUOUS

As the field mouse scampers, a huge lion paw THUDS into frame and traps the mouse in its jail-like claws. PULL BACK TO REVEAL:

SCAR, a thin, angular lion with an attitude problem. He gingerly lifts the mouse by its tail and dangles it over his gaping mouth. Rather than eat the mouse, Scar rolls it through his paw the way a gambler rolls a coin.

SCAR

Life's not fair. Yes -- You see, I shall never be king. And you shall never see another day. Adieu.

As Scar is about to eat the mouse, he HEARS:

ZAZU (O.S.)

Didn't your mother ever tell you not to play with your food?

SCAR

Oh, Zazu. What do you want?

REVEAL Zazu, the hornbill we met in the opening scene. Zazu blends regal with ironic edge. He reveres his boss (King Mufasa) and disdains anyone he perceives to be a low-life cretin -- which is pretty much everybody but the King.

ZAZU

I'm here to announce that King Mufasa's on his way. And you'd better have a good excuse for missing the ceremony this morning.

The little mouse escapes to freedom.

SCAR

(mock sad)

Now look, Zazu. You've made me lose my lunch.

ZAZU

You'll lose more than that when the king gets through with you. He's as mad as a hippo with a hernia.

Scar, licking his chops, advances on Zazu -- who backs away.

SCAR

Ooooo. I quiver with fear.

ZAZU

Now, Scar -- Don't look at me that way.

Scar continues stalking.

ZAZU (CONT'D)

Help!

Scar catches Zazu in his mouth. And CHOMPS his teeth shut. Mufasa enters, having witnessed what Scar just did.

MUFASA

(admonishing)

Scar!

Scar, surprised, and with a bird bulge in his mouth:

SCAR

Hmm?

With that, Zazu's beak pokes out from Scar's lips. It looks like the mouth-within-a-mouth in "Alien."

ZAZU'S BEAK

Impeccable timing, Your Majesty.

MUFASA

(to a disobedient puppy)

Drop him!

SCAR
(releasing Zazu)
Plegh!

Zazu tumbles to the ground and shakes off.

SCAR
(to Mufasa)
Why if it isn't my big brother,
descending from on high to mingle
among the commoners.

MUFASA
Sarabi and I didn't see you at the
presentation of Simba.
(genuine)
Is anything wrong?

SCAR
(insincere)
That was today? Oh, I feel simply
awful. Must have slipped my mind.

ZAZU
Yes, well as slippery as your mind
is -- as the king's brother, you
should have been first in line.

Scar nips at Zazu -- who evades him.

SCAR
I was first in line until the little
hairball was born.

MUFASA
That hairball is my son and your
future king.

SCAR
I shall practice my curtsy.

Scar abruptly turns to walk away. Mufasa calls after him:

MUFASA
Don't turn your back on me, Scar!

Scar reels back around.

SCAR
Oh, no, Mufasa. Perhaps you
shouldn't turn your back on me.

MUFASA
Is that a challenge?